Building brand equity

(A presentation given at the Medical Marketing Association Annual Conference)

Received (in revised form): 22nd February, 2002

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Keywords *brand equity, branding, consumers' perceptions of brands*

Abstract This paper will consider four questions of branding:

- What is a brand?
- What is it that brands do for us; what is the power of brands?
- What is the brand equity concept?
- What is a model for thinking about building strong brands in one's own organisation?

WHAT IS A BRAND?

Brands are an integral part of today's marketplace. Everywhere one looks there are brands, and strong brands are the most successful products across a wide variety of product categories.

The quote '*An orange is an orange, is an orange, unless, of course, that orange happens to be a Sunkist*', a name 80 per cent of consumers know and trust, gives an indication of what a successful brand does. The two concepts – consumer knowledge and trust – sum up what brands and brand equity develop; those are the issues that are at the heart of the brand and of building a brand that has a good relationship with the customer.

The American Marketing Association defines a brand as: 'a name, term, sign, symbol or design, or a combination of these, that identifies the goods or services of one seller or group of sellers and differentiates them from those of the competition.' The notion that a brand is something that identifies the goods from one person, as separate from the goods of another person, is a 'historically-based' look at brands. It is the notion of a 'mark' placed on a product to separate it from the rest.

A brand however, is much more than this. A brand is a promise a company makes to the customer, of what this product is going to deliver. That is, how the brand is going to fit into the business of the customer. The brand promise is a commitment by the organisation, as making a promise to the customer is something that has to be followed through. It is important that the organisation understands that by making this brand promise, they have to live up to it. The creation of a strong brand is something the company is going to have to commit to, in order to make it work.

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WHAT CAN BE BRANDED?

Many people ask whether everything can be branded, or if there are types of products that cannot be branded. People say, 'Oh sure, you know, consumer goods products; it makes a lot of sense to brand those. But what about if I'm in hi-tech? What if I'm in medical marketing? What if I have rational customers? Does the brand matter in this situation as well?'

The research that has been done on this shows that, yes, branding does matter in these circumstances. Brands have been found to give an important competitive advantage across a wide variety of industries. In commodities, for example, Morton Salt is the most successful brand of salt with the most successful sales. It is however, mined from the same mine as other brands of salt.

Novar is a high technology business-to-business company that builds climate controls for large buildings. In the 1990s they were doing well, but not outstandingly so. In 1999, they began a branding campaign that involved a variety of strategies. They specifically rationalised names, by choosing names that had meaning. They started to concentrate on branding the sub-product as well as the Novar brand itself. They found that within the first seven months of their campaign, they had a 26 per cent increase in profitability, which they attributed to their branding.

What about medical products? Brands clearly have power in this industry, with over-the-counter products. For example, people know and trust certain headache brands. Prescriptions have also clearly seen a big change, where brands that are being built, are aimed at the consumer, i.e. the end-user, rather than just at the intermediary level. In the case of procedures, Lasik surgery is a good example, where the brand itself is becoming quite powerful. This is also true for devices: Perclose and HP Ultrasound Monitors are examples of brands that have been built in these areas and which have added to the power of those products.

This is the basic idea of what a brand is, and an indication that brands are important and relevant in different domains. But what is the basis of this importance, and where is the brand's power within the marketplace?

BRAND POWER

There are two real sources of power: One derives from the customers' perspective and whether customers perceive that the brand provides value and meaning. If they do believe it does, then the brand reduces search costs, and this is important to consumers who lead busy lives, and have too many choices to make. Brands help customers by reducing the effort required to choose a good product. Once the initial search is completed by the consumer, and the consumer has built trust and understanding in the brand, this may be carried through to an extended product, which then cuts down the search process in the extended category.

Trust in the brand also mitigates perceived risks. For example, if a parent has to go out in the middle of the night to buy a pain-killer for his child, then the name, eg Tylenol, is going to be very helpful in that purchase. They understand what they are getting, and they believe that it is a less risky choice because it is a brand they know. Thus, the brand also helps with interpretation, with processing and the confidence that people have in the choices that they make.

The brand also gives other benefits – benefits of self-expression. These tend to apply more in the consumer goods, and business-to-business realms. In business-to-business, branding can be of great importance: for example, there is a professional food mixer called the 'Hobart' brand, which is the 'Mercedes' of professional mixers. Research has demonstrated that chefs really believe that having what they perceive to be the best, eg, the Hobart, will allow them to produce the best.

There is also the issue of providing user satisfaction. The idea that 'by using this particular brand I am benefiting, because I know that I'm using the best. I know that I'm using something that has quality and in which I have faith'.

From the marketer perspective, it can be seen that brands are very important, because they are an effective way to secure a sustainable, competitive advantage. The brand allows improved identification of the product, and the likelihood of a repeat purchase. Brands are a real way to build customer loyalty. They increase the ability to differentiate products, within a line and apart from competitors. They allow for segmentation, and enable a company to produce different brands for different groups of customers. Brands provide a means for legal protection – and this is an added protection for the particular bundle of attributes on offer.

A very important part of branding is the facilitation of new product introduction; the notion of 'extending'. The thing that allows you to extend to a new territory, into a new country, is very often the brand and the faith that people have in that.

Finally, the brand offers a source of financial return. The research on the benefits of strong brands, looking across companies, shows that companies gain greater loyalty because of brands. A strong brand makes people purchase it more often. It creates resistance to competitive marketing action. This means that when the competitor comes up with a new campaign, lowers the price, etc, a strong brand will help the customer to stay with you.

Larger margins can stem from strong brands. Strong brands gain the ultimate in pricing. Strong brands have less elastic responses to price increases and more elastic responses to price decreases. That is, strong brands are able to raise their prices without having as many people switch, but when a strong brand lowers the price, more consumers come in than in the case of the less strong brand.

The brand can positively impact all marketing tools. Some of the author's own research shows that communication efficiency and effectiveness is higher for strong brands. Marketing communications are read more, processed more deeply and understood better when they are coming from a strong brand source. There are obviously licensing and extension opportunities. There is greater trade cooperation and support. People are more willing to listen and are more willing to invite you into their home. People are more willing to support the new product coming from a strong brand. When a strong brand makes a mistake, people treat it with more leniency and with more kindness than they do if it is a mistake from a weaker brand.

WHAT IS A BRAND EQUITY?

'A product is something that is made in a factory. A brand is something that is bought by a customer. A product can be copied by a competitor, a brand is unique. A product can be quickly outdated. A successful brand is timeless,' Stephen King, WPP Group.

Some of this is true and some of this is not. This speaks of the power of brands, but a successful brand is not timeless. A successful brand is something that has seen a lot of effort in its creation and it needs continuous management and work to maintain it. A brand is something that has to be worked on constantly. This quote does capture the three sorts of ideas of the brand equity concept. (1) A strong brand is important for marketing success. The brand does have the benefits and the power that were discussed earlier. The effects of other marketing actions are going to be dependent upon the brand that is created. (2) Brand equity represents an added value. This is what you have 'gained' due to your efforts to create that strong brand. Brand equity is the difference in the effects realised in the marketplace due to the investment and the work put into the brand. (3) The brand must be continuously managed. Again, this is something that is going to take a lot of work. It is going to take a lot of commitment and it is going to be an ongoing process. So, what is the process? How do we create and how do we manage a strong brand?

There are two definitions of brand equity from two of the biggest thinkers in the area. The first: 'a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name and symbol that add to or subtract from the value provided by a product or service to a firm or to that firm's customers,' Dave Aaker.[1] This is really talking about the elements that are 'owned', that provide value or detract from the value that our customers associate with the product. For example, the colour that has been associated with the brand. Kodak's gold colour, for example, is a brand asset.

The second definition is 'the differential effect that brand knowledge has on consumer response to the marketing of that brand', by Kevin Lane Keller, based on the idea of how value is added by the things that are linked to the brand.[2] This expressed the idea that brand equity really is – once we take these symbols and things that are linked to the brand – the differential effect that brand knowledge has on customer response to the brand and to the efforts that we make in the marketplace. Again, the example is Kodak 'Gold'. That is an asset that is linked to the brand; it has meaning. The reason it has meaning is because it changes peoples' perception. It changes their willingness to do business in a variety of ways with products because of the meaning that the gold colour has to them. Kodak has done a number of tests where they have printed marketing communications on different colours of paper. When they print it on Kodak Gold, the processing that they receive from their customers goes up. Memory goes up, understanding of the contents of the advertisement goes up and the positive attitudes towards whatever new piece of equipment they are advertising, increases. That is brand equity. That is really where it can be said: 'Okay, our efforts in investing and creating this sense are really paying off in the marketplace. The brand is improving the other things that we do'. That is what should be achieved.

It is important to realise that both of these definitions suggest that 'brand equity' can be positive, but it can be negative. We need to understand when we are in a situation where brand equity actually hurts our brand. A consumer product example is J. Gallo Brandy. For years, they would find that if they did a blind taste test, consumers liked them. As soon as they put their name on the product however, ratings went down. They worked a long time to overcome that negative equity of the brand name.

There are two sources of brandy equity. Equity arises from whether customers are *aware* of the brand, and customers' *knowledge* about the brand. Customers have a set of associations of what the brand means, and what it delivers. They have ideas of what they can expect, in terms of the relationship, and in terms of the product's delivery. Associations can be anything the customer links to the brand. These associations connect the customer to the brand. Product attributes, use situations, users, organisational associations, brand personality, symbols: these are all associations that customers will link to a brand.

Perceived quality is a very special type of association. It is very important to all kinds of customers, has been shown to influence other associations and has been empirically demonstrated to effect profitability, both in terms of return on investment and in terms of stock return.

Some people consider brand loyalty to be a separate part of brand equity. It is clearly very important and it influences the value of the brand. The author believes, however, that it really comes out of awareness and association. Brand loyalty is again what arises from strong brand equity. It is more like a measure of the equity of the brand, than a part of the equity. However, do not ignore brand loyalty, because it is critically important to managing the brand.

In order to create a strong brand, you need to go to customers. It is necessary to look at the marketplace and to understand the associations that are important to that market, and to those customers. Those are the associations that you want to build up and link with your brand. They should be favourable, strong and unique, so that a differentiated, positive position is created in the customer's mind.

Thus, the process of building strong brands is two-fold: 1) development of awareness for your brand in your target customer, and 2) the particular associations — strong, favourable and unique — that will build a relevant, differentiated position in the customer's mind.

BRAND AWARENESS

Brand awareness can be considered as a continuum. The top of the brand awareness pyramid is the only brand recalled. It is very unlikely that you will be the only one recalled for a product category. The level of brand awareness that most people aim for is the notion of 'top of mind recall.' This is where a customer in the relevant target segment, when thinking about the need that the product satisfies, recalls that brand. The customer thinks, 'Ah, yes, this is a way for me to solve these needs'.

Recall refers to the ability to remember a brand, given a set of needs or product category. Recognition is the ability to recognise a product, without being able to recall it without the prompt. Most memory for most products, is in either the recognition or the unaware level.

A strong brand should have, at the very least, recall, and really should preferably be in top-of-mind. Recall and top-of-mind awareness are often necessary for inclusion in the consideration set that drives a lot of decision-making.

BRAND ASSOCIATIONS

The three 'Cs' of marketing – customer analysis, competitor analysis, and company analysis – are critical to choosing the associations that you would like to link to your brand in order to build strong brand equity. It is absolutely critical to begin with insightful analysis. Customer analysis is clearly necessary to understand what customers think of your brand currently, what they think of the competitive landscape and what they want. You must go beneath what they easily say, to why they do what they do and what is important in that area. These deeper associations are the ones that will really resonate.

You must understand the competitors to understand what they are doing, what their current and potential strategies are in order to choose a strategy that will differentiate your brand in ways that are meaningful in the minds of customers.

Company analysis may be thought of as psychoanalysis for the company. Again, it is important that the organisation commits to the brand associations. Thus, analyse the extent to which the organisation has the resources, the capability and the will to deliver on the brand promise. Explore the brand heritage, the current image, the strengths, the weaknesses, the limitations of the existing company, the strategies and the values of the organisation at large, in order to make sure that any associations fit within that larger organisational structure. A brand promise has to be followed through and business strategy and brand strategy must be intertwined. The analyses will determine the associations that are meaningful and relevant to customers, that the company can and has the will to provide and follow up consistently. Market analysis is the basis upon which to position your particular brand within the competitive landscape, to make sure that those associations again allow a differentiated position from what else is there and what is likely to be there. Differentiation can be created by product performance, by the specific attributes that are offered, by the service that is provided along with the product. It can also be based on image, on the relationship, on the personality that goes with the brand. Differentiation is reflected in the associations the customers have for the brand at the end of the day. Strong, favourable and unique associations serve as the basis of the differentiated position.

It should be emphasised that in consideration of positioning, in order to create brand equity, you need to include the primary competitors, that market space in which the brand is going to be competing and the key differentiators.

This is the act of designing the company's offer and image, so that it occupies a distinct and valued place in the target customers' minds. These are the associations that we are trying to create. A brand is really much more than a product. There is at the centre of any brand, the product, the attributes, the quality that is being offered, the value relationship that is being offered, the functional benefits and the scope of the product solutions. But more than that, you have a variety of additional associations. You have, for instance, the self-expressive benefit from the brand personality. Again, often, people think 'Well, brand personality, that really doesn't matter in certain kinds of business-to-business industries'. But it does. If you do not build a brand personality; if you do not choose how your brand is going to come across, customers may say: 'Oh, yeah, that company, they're very cold; they're too business oriented.' A lack of a personality becomes the personality. Choices need to be made about what you want that to be. Country of origin and relationships can also matter. What you can do, is choose a set of these overall associations to be the core basis of the brand associations that you put in the marketplace. You will want to choose what is meaningful in your market, what will bring additional power to your marketing efforts.

The positioning is part of the overall brand identity that exists. It is the part of the brand strategies that we have decided to actively communicate to the target audience. It can be considered the core differentiation for the target customers. All brands have multiple associations. Some of these are considered to be more important to the creation and maintenance of the brand than others. Those are the things that we want to identify and understand in order to actively manage the brand.

One thing that is clear from analyses of successful and unsuccessful companies is that it is necessary to be very careful in selecting the associations to link to a brand. The selection of an identity means a choice of a target customer. That is a fact of life that we need to accept and understand. When you are saying, 'Out of all the things that we could be, this is what we're going to be,' some people are going to like that more than others. Again, that is why the customer analysis is important, to understand what customers should be targeted; which customers have the ability to bond with the brand.

Strong identities and positions are extremely difficult to change once they are created. We have seen the upside of brand equity – building strong brands create power in the marketplace. However, once brand associations exist, they are very difficult to change. For example, Avon has been working to change a strong brand identity for almost 25 years. Customer analysis shows that the strongest associations that customers have with Avon are 'ding-dong' and 'Avon Lady.' They have not used either of those terms in any form of marketing communication in many years, but those associations are difficult to dislodge, even though society has changed to where they are no longer relevant to Avon customers. Associations thus, must be chosen carefully, based on thorough, up front analysis. Get to the point of saying 'Yes, this is something we really think is going to work, in the long run. We're predicting that this is going to take us forward with the customers we're interested in.'

Bear in mind that things change in the industry, time marches on and there is a variety of differences that make your position and those associations less relevant than they were originally. Thus, if there is cause to change the identity, it must be done in gradual steps. The temptation is often just to make an immediate big change, but that rarely works. What does work is to take intermediary positions and move the whole distance over time. Everyone has heard of Levis. Some time ago they decided to enter the formal suit market. They came straight out with the Levis formal suits, which were a failure. This made them realise 'we can't go from this equity of a rugged and western casual heritage to something people are going to wear to formal business engagements – just like that. What we need to do is take small steps that will move us there over time.' They then introduced Dockers, very successfully. Dockers moved up from jeans but it was not a huge step. Consumers could understand the relationship between jeans and casual khakis. Then Levis introduced the Slates line, which is higher than casual, but it is certainly not a dress suit. They are now moving positions with small steps.

A MODEL FOR BUILDING STRONG BRANDS

The Young & Rubicam Brand Asset Valuator model. This is a model way of how to build a strong brand. This is based on work that was conducted with over 35,000 brands over 30 years, looking at what it is that differentiates brands that are successfully able to develop and maintain as a strong brand, versus those that are not. This work shows four 'pillars' of brand strength. The most critical pillar is *differentiation*, ie, how it is that the brand is different from whatever else exists in the marketplace. The next pillar is *relevance*. This is the personal appropriateness of the brand. What does it mean for the target customer? How does it resonate with the target customer? How does it fit into the target customer's life? A lot of niche brands have high relevance for a small group, but not a lot of relevance for the rest of the world. For example, Rolls Royce: most of us do not own one, but we know about it; there is a lot of differentiation. We know that it is different but it is just not relevant for most of us. The third pillar is the '*esteem*,' or regard that people have for the brand. The perceived popularity, the perceived market acceptance, the perceived quality. The last pillar is *knowledge*. This is really the understanding of the brand. The customer knows about it and knows what it stands for.

One of the important things about this model is the idea that brand growth needs to be in this order. Strong brands start with differentiation, understanding and building how it is they are different from the competition. This approach is different from a common one in which people normally say, 'Oh, we just have got to get our name out there. We just have to have knowledge. Everybody is going to know about us.' Regarding the Super Bowl 2000, with a lot of the dot.com advertising, that is what it was about – knowledge – and they forgot about differentiation and distinctiveness to their sorrow. You have to start with the differentiation, even if that means starting on a small scale. Differentiation is the driver of the brand. Without differentiation, customers are going to have no basis for selection. Manufacturers are going to have no reason to expect loyalty. Consumers are going to want to pay less if they do not know why it is that they should be paying more!

The data indicate that successful brands develop differentiation first. Then they develop relevance; then esteem; then knowledge. This is the way to develop a brand, and the order of emphasis. Without a differentiated position, brands are very likely to decline. With the differentiated position there is a reason for customers to get to know more about the brand, and a reason to build up esteem and knowledge. This is not to suggest that differentiation is the only component. Differentiation alone is not going to build a strong brand. Brand strength is based both on differentiation and relevance, how the brand is different, and why the customer cares. A strong brand also has the stature of esteem and knowledge.

Figure 1 shows the Y&R brand power grid. This shows brand stature across the bottom, brand strength moving up the side. There is a variety of very new or unfocused or stagnant brands in the first quadrant, where there is low brand stature and low brand strength. The brands are new and they have to work up to build the relevance and differentiation that take them into the unrealised potential or niche market quadrant. The quadrant with high brand strength, low brand stature, indicates brands with high differentiation and some degree of relevance, but with some lesser degree of knowledge and esteem. What they do at that point is critical to what happens to the brand. Some brands stay there. The niche brands stay there with high relevance to a small market segment, but low relevance to the rest of the world. However, some brands are then able to move into the leadership position. That is where there is strength on all four pillars. The leadership quadrant companies, eg Microsoft, and Nike, have

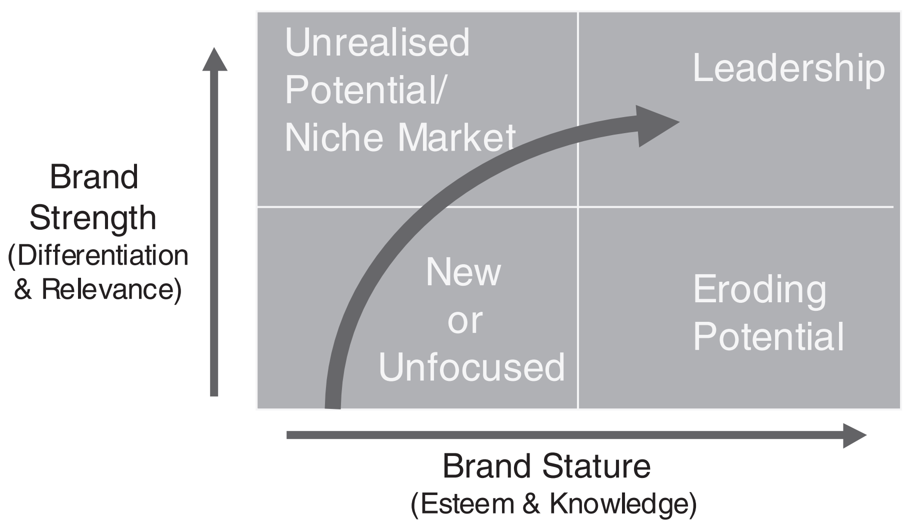

Figure 1 Y&R brand power grid

high differentiation, high relevance, high esteem and high knowledge.

The final quadrant is one where we often see companies that were doing well, but allow themselves to slip, often due to societal changes that they're not able to respond to effectively. For example, Greyhound used to be a differentiated transportation alternative. Now, it is unlikely that many people here have actually ridden on a Greyhound. Changes made bus transportation less relevant to US consumers. In the eroding potential quadrant, companies no longer have differentiation, even though they often have high knowledge.

CREATING STRONG BRANDS

In order to create a strong brand, it is necessary to start with a great product. Branding is not smoke and mirrors. When a brand makes a promise that it has these great associations, relevance and differentiation, the brand must support it. It is necessary to provide superior delivery of desired benefits that have been associated with the brand. The second step is determining what brand associations are going to be; what the relevant, differentiated positioning is that will work in the particular marketplace. The third step is then to communicate the brand identity to the target customers. This involves a lot of decision-making: choosing the brand elements that will become associated with that brand; communicating associations consistently throughout the marketing mix and leveraging the secondary associations. Think of the product as being in the middle of other broader associations around the product attributes. We need to select the core identity, the primary associations for the brand. There are also secondary associations. These have to be managed, to build the overall sense of the brand. The schematic in Fig. 2 is a good way to think about it. What we are looking for is to get to the far right side. Those are the benefits that we discussed. A strong brand offers loyalty, resistance to competition, larger margins, etc. In order to get there, we need to build brand awareness and brand associations.

Figure 3 shows several steps to consider when building the brand. One is the desired customer position, which we have already covered. In some cases, you may

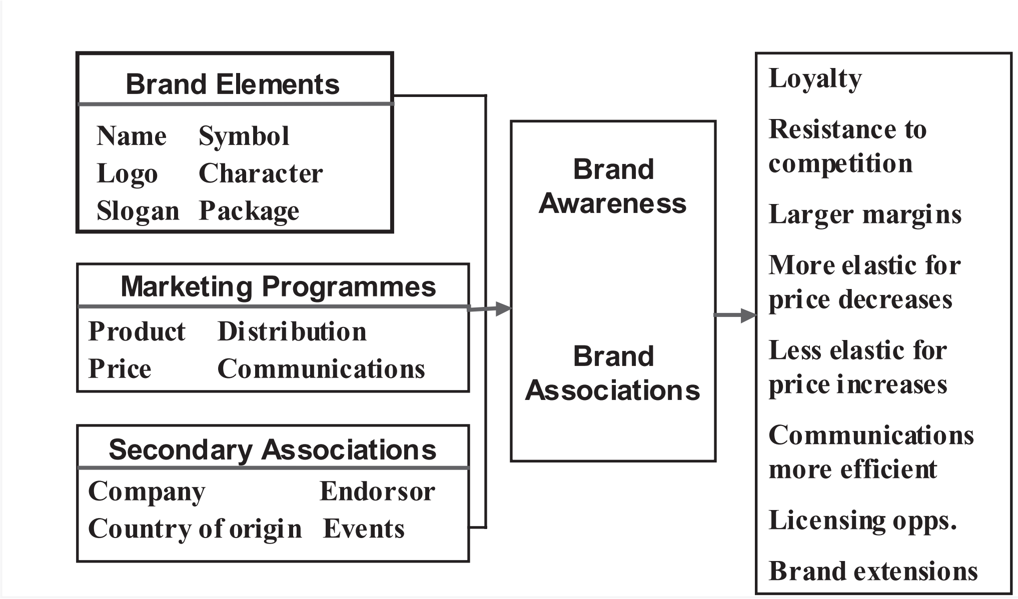

Figure 2 Creating strong brands

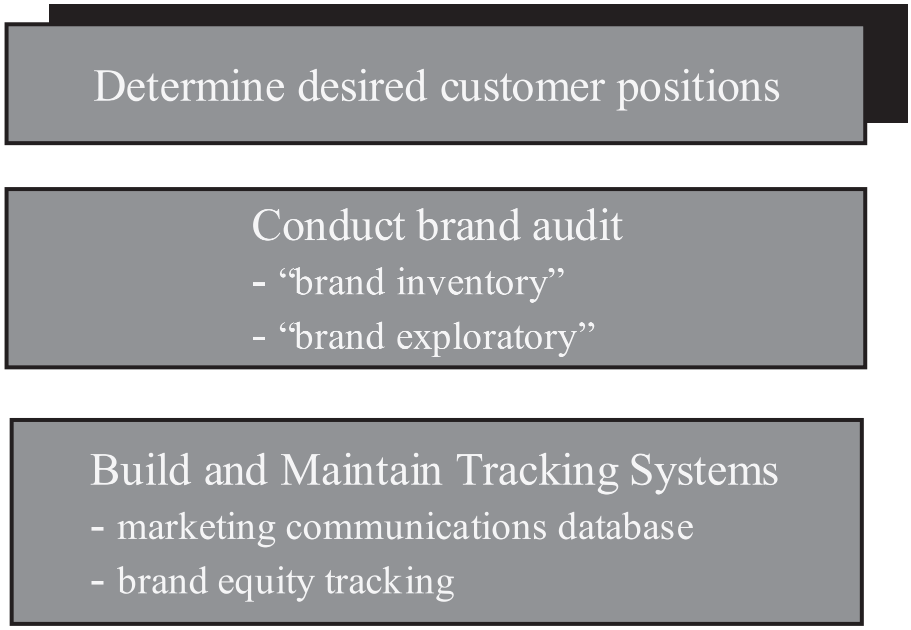

Figure 3 Building the brand

be creating brands from scratch. More often you will be managing brands that already exist in one way or another. You will be making decisions about the overall brand architecture that already exists: what brands are going to be more and less powerful, what has to be omitted, and what new associations or different associations should be built up. In order to do that, the brand audit is an important tool. There are two components. (1) *The brand inventory* – the internal look. The brand inventory asks: 'What currently is the way that we deal with this brand? What does every piece of communication look like? What is the identity that we're building? How do we tell people about it? What is the position in communications? What does our trade show look like and how do these things fit together?' (2) *The brand exploratory*, which asks: 'Okay, we know what we are doing. How does that come across?' This involves going to customers and finding out what they think of the brand. What are the associations in the customers' minds that have been built? What do they see as having happened with this particular brand? This consumer insight is critical to understanding the brand. We may think we have been putting in a great deal of effort for the particular position, but it is not coming across that way to our customers. Once we know what the gap is between what we want and what exists in customers' minds, then we put something into place in order to move the brand in the desired direction. There should be a tracking system in place in order to understand how you are moving forward, the extent to which you are achieving these goals. Finally, there also needs to be a good and easily accessible understanding of the various ways we communicate with the customers and how that is presenting the brand. This is the communication database. This is particularly important in industries where the primary point of contact with customers is a live person. If we do not know how the brand is being presented at that critical live interaction with the customer, then we do not have a good way of assessing and understanding the associations that are being built up and the fit between our various kinds of communication and that most critical one.

CONCLUSION

Strong brands provide value and have a variety of benefits. To customers, brands provide direction, they provide reassurance. Brands reduce risks and they provide a way to self-express. To marketers, brands provide a competitive advantage. They provide the means and the way of differentiation. Brands provide a means for segmentation for different markets, and a point of entry into new categories that are going to bring greater financial return. Strong brands are based on a relevant differentiated position. Without that, you cannot build a strong brand. A variety of associations are linked to a strong brand. Sometimes we can get carried away, saying 'This is the most important thing to customers; this is what we should link', and we forget there needs to be more than any one single association. If you look at strong brands, they have a couple of very good sources of strength and a bigger picture of what the brand means and how it is relevant to the customer.

The associations that are built for the brand need to be based on careful and thorough analyses of the customers, of the competitors and of the company. It must be emphasised that the organisation must be committed to the brand, both philosophically and financially. Only a small portion of brand efforts will have a payoff in the short run. In fact, much of the process of brand building will cost the organisation in the short run. Branding is a long-run proposition that the organisation must be committed to in order to live up to the brand promise that is made. Internally, you can ask yourselves two questions: first, what does our brand stand for? Secondly, do we really care? If the answer to the second one is 'no,' then branding is not for you. Going into the market and making a promise and then breaking it is worse than never making a promise at all.

Strong brands arise from the thorough integration of the brand throughout the entire marketing mix. The three Cs of branding, are *Consistency, Clarity* and *Convergence*. Everything has to work together to build identified brand content.

In conclusion, brands must be carefully and constantly nurtured over time. This is not a one shot deal; this is something that we have to be in for the long run. The author recently moved to the University of Colorado, at Boulder, from UCLA, in California. Among the variety of differences seen so far, one is that in Colorado, raw fish is bait. In California, raw fish is sushi, and in Los Angeles, raw fish is Spago sushi. What you want is to manage your brand so that it is not just fish, but attains 'Spago sushi' associations. That is, manage your brand to provide meaning to your customers. Manage such that your customers have a deep understanding of the product, believe that your brand will deliver on its brand promise, and trust your brand and its role in their lives.

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